

Frequently Asked Questions

ctrlaltcrew — Client FAQ

This document collects frequently asked questions from prospective clients, grouped by topic, with concise answers consistent with the rest of the knowledge base.

General

Q: What does ctrlaltcrew do?

A: ctrlaltcrew is a software and applied-AI development studio that builds custom web applications, mobile apps, e-commerce platforms, backend/APIs, and AI/LLM-powered systems for businesses and startups.

Q: Who are your typical clients?

A: Small and medium businesses, startups, and teams that need a custom software or AI solution but don't have an in-house engineering team. See the Company Overview document for a full breakdown of target clients.

Q: Do you only work on AI projects, or also regular software development?

A: Both. ctrlaltcrew builds traditional web, mobile, e-commerce, and backend projects as well as AI/LLM-powered applications, and often combines the two (e.g., a web app with an embedded chatbot).

Q: How do I start a project with ctrlaltcrew?

A: Start with an initial consultation describing your business and what you need. From there, the team gathers requirements, defines scope, and provides an estimate before any development begins. See the Project Development Process document for full detail.

Web and Mobile Development

Q: Do you build mobile applications?

A: Yes. ctrlaltcrew develops mobile applications for iOS, Android, or both, using native or cross-platform frameworks depending on the project's needs and budget.

Q: Can you build a website for my business?

A: Yes. Web development ranges from a Basic Website (a small informational site) up to a full Business Web Application with user accounts and custom features.

Q: What's the difference between a basic website and a business web application?

A: A Basic Website is a small, mostly informational site (up to about 5 pages) with no user accounts. A Business Web Application includes custom functionality such as user accounts, an admin dashboard, and database-backed features tailored to a specific workflow.

Q: Do you offer both iOS and Android apps in one build?

A: Yes, through cross-platform development, which uses a single codebase for both platforms. This is typically faster and less expensive than building separate native apps for each.

Q: Can you redesign my existing website or app?

A: Yes. Redesign and modernization projects are common; the team will review the existing product during requirement gathering and scope the redesign accordingly.

E-Commerce

Q: Can you build an e-commerce website?

A: Yes. E-Commerce Development includes a product catalog, cart and checkout, payment gateway integration, and an admin panel for managing products and orders.

Q: Can you integrate a payment gateway into my store?

A: Yes, payment gateway integration is a standard part of the E-Commerce Application package.

Q: Do you support multi-vendor marketplaces?

A: Multi-vendor marketplace functionality is possible but goes beyond the standard E-Commerce Application package; it is scoped and estimated individually due to its added complexity.

Q: Can I migrate my existing store to a new platform?

A: Yes, store migrations are a common project type within the E-Commerce Development service.

Backend and API Development

Q: Do you provide API development?

A: Yes. Backend & API Development includes REST or GraphQL API design, database design, authentication, and third-party integrations.

Q: Can you integrate third-party APIs into my product?

A: Yes, integrating with third-party services (payment gateways, CRMs, messaging providers, and other APIs) is a routine part of both backend and application development projects.

Q: Can you build just the backend, without a frontend?

A: Yes, a standalone backend/API can be built independently, for example to serve a mobile app or to connect existing systems together.

Q: Do you work with existing databases or systems?

A: Yes, the team can work with an existing backend or database to add features, build a new API layer, or modernize the system.

AI and LLM Services

Q: Do you develop AI chatbots?

A: Yes. AI Chatbots & Virtual Assistants is a core service, covering LLM-powered assistants for customer support, lead capture, and FAQ answering.

Q: Can an AI chatbot answer questions from company documents?

A: Yes, but this requires a RAG (Retrieval-Augmented Generation) pipeline rather than a standard chatbot. See 'What is RAG?' below and the RAG-Based Knowledge Assistants service for detail.

Q: What is RAG?

A: RAG stands for Retrieval-Augmented Generation. It's a technique where an AI system retrieves relevant passages from a client's own documents (stored as searchable embeddings) and uses them as context when generating an answer, so responses are grounded in the client's actual content instead of relying only on the AI's general knowledge.

Q: Can you build an AI system like this RAG chatbot for my business?

A: Yes. A RAG-based knowledge assistant can be built for a business. It can ingest company documents, retrieve relevant information, and use an LLM to answer questions based on the provided knowledge base.

Q: What's the difference between a chatbot and an AI agent?

A: A chatbot primarily answers questions or holds a conversation. An AI agent goes further: it can take multi-step actions using tools or APIs (e.g., updating a record, sending a notification) to complete a task, not just respond with information.

Q: Do you build AI systems that can take actions, not just answer questions?

A: Yes, this falls under Agentic AI & Workflow Automation, where the AI is given defined tools/actions it can use to complete multi-step tasks.

Q: What information do you need to build a RAG chatbot for my business?

A: Primarily the source documents or content the assistant should answer from (in a readable format such as PDF, Word, or spreadsheets), how often that content changes, and whether answers need to cite specific source documents.

Q: Will the AI make up answers if it doesn't know something?

A: RAG systems are specifically designed to reduce this risk by grounding answers in provided documents and can be configured to state when information isn't available in the knowledge base, rather than guessing.

Q: Can the AI assistant work in a language other than English?

A: Multilingual support depends on the underlying language model and can be included in scope; this should be specified during requirement gathering.

Pricing and Timelines

Q: How much does a website cost?

A: A Basic Website is estimated at \$800–\$1,500, while a full Business Web Application ranges from \$2,500–\$6,000, depending on required features. See the Project Packages and Estimated Pricing document for the full breakdown.

Q: How much does an AI chatbot cost?

A: An FAQ/customer support chatbot is estimated at \$1,500–\$4,000. A RAG-based knowledge assistant that answers from your own documents is estimated at \$3,500–\$9,000, reflecting the added work of document ingestion and retrieval setup.

Q: How much does a custom AI/LLM application cost?

A: Custom AI applications involving agentic workflows are estimated at \$6,000–\$15,000 or more, depending on the number of systems integrated and the complexity of the automation.

Q: How long does a typical project take?

A: Timelines vary by project type: a Basic Website takes about 2–3 weeks, a Business Web Application 4–8 weeks, and an E-Commerce Application 5–9 weeks. AI/LLM project timelines typically range from 3–14 weeks depending on the type and complexity of the project: AI chatbots may take 3–5 weeks, RAG-based knowledge assistants 5–9 weeks, and custom agentic AI applications 8–14 weeks. Full detail is in the Project Packages and Estimated Pricing document.

Q: What information do you need before giving an estimate?

A: At minimum: business type, project type, target users, required features, platform, and any integrations. See the Project Requirements Guide for the full checklist, including AI-specific requirements.

Q: Are these prices final?

A: No. The figures in the pricing document are demonstration estimates and starting reference ranges. A firm price is provided after requirement gathering, once the specific scope is confirmed.

Q: What can increase the cost of my project?

A: Common cost drivers include additional custom features, more user roles, third-party integrations, larger or more complex source-document sets for AI projects, custom design work, and support for multiple platforms. See the Project Packages document for the full list of cost factors.

Process and Support

Q: Can an existing application be upgraded?

A: Yes. Upgrading or extending an existing application — adding features, building an API layer, or modernizing outdated code — is a common project type.

Q: Do you provide post-launch support?

A: Yes. Projects include an initial warranty period after launch, and clients can choose an ongoing support and maintenance plan for updates, bug fixes, and enhancements. See the Support and Maintenance document for details.

Q: What happens if I don't know all my requirements yet?

A: That's normal. The team can provide a rough estimate range from partial information and will ask targeted follow-up questions to complete the requirements before finalizing scope and price.

Q: Can I request changes after development has started?

A: Changes within the original scope are handled during the Client Review stage. Changes that expand the original scope are treated as an addition and may affect price and timeline, which the team will flag before proceeding.

Q: Do you sign contracts or provide written agreements for projects?

A: Projects are formalized with a written scope and estimate that both parties agree to before development begins, as described in the Project Development Process document. Specific contractual and legal terms are handled directly with the ctrlaltcrew team.